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Update from Acting AA for Fisheries Emily Menashes

1 message

Trusted NMFS Sender - NOAA Service Account <trusted.nmfs.sender@noaa.gov> Fri, Mar 14, 2025 at 7:11 AM
To: _NMFS All Hands <nmfs.all@noaa.gov>

Good morning/Good afternoon:

It's been a while since you have heard from me directly and I wanted to check in and provide some updates and information. I also want you to know that the valuable work you do is very important now and will continue to be well into the future. This is an uneasy time for everyone, but through it all, I deeply appreciate your focus on our mission and its value to the country.

Recently, we saw the departure of many of our colleagues and I want to take a moment here to honor them and their service to the agency. In addition, I encourage each of you to take some time to reflect on your own public service—what it means to you, to your colleagues, and to the countless Americans who rely on NOAA every day. We can continue to honor the long history of public service conducted by our colleagues, past and present, by working together to forge a better tomorrow. Equally important, extend grace to yourself and others and take time to honor your own wellbeing.

With that in mind, I want to extend a special thank you to all of the Fisheries employees who have picked up critical work to keep the mission going. Thank you to those of you who have had to change your work arrangements and adjust your lives to be in the office. Thank you to those of you who have been tirelessly working on the many short-turnaround tasks we've had to respond to. Another thank you to our headquarters, regional, and science center leadership who have been working closely with me, Sam Rauch, Cisco Werner, and Brian Pawlak to stay up to date on new policies and guidance. Everyone has pitched in, and as a result, I feel confident in saying that we have represented our mission in the best possible light to NOAA and the Department.

I also want to acknowledge the dialogue in the news and other spaces concerning a reduction in force (RIF), future budgets, position classifications, and other topics that impact the federal workforce. While I cannot predict the future, I can assure you that leaders at every level of Fisheries and NOAA continue to work together to approach any incoming change with intentionality, discernment, and integrity. Also, I want you to know that all of these are activities that have to follow prescribed timelines and processes before any action can be taken.

We are also preparing for a possible lapse in appropriations. If that happens, your supervisor will notify you of your status and we will follow our plan for an orderly shutdown. Most federal employees will be in a furlough status and not allowed to conduct official agency business or to use agency email or phones. However, as in the past, a few activities will continue, including law enforcement, observer activities, and regulatory actions to prevent overfishing. Please stay tuned as this potential scenario unfolds.

Turning the focus back to the amazing work Fisheries employees do every day, I have two accolades to celebrate. First, our Senior Advisor for Seafood Strategy Dr. Michael Rubino recently received a Distinguished Lifetime Achievement Award from the U.S. Chapter of the World Aquaculture Society and a Distinguished Career Award from the National Aquaculture Association in ceremonies held at the Aquaculture America conference. The recognition of Michael's exceptional leadership and ground-breaking work to ensure a more robust domestic seafood supply is well deserved. Please join me in congratulating Michael on these awards.

Additionally, the Oregon Chapter of the American Fisheries Society presented our Northwest Fisheries Science Center colleague, Dr. Laurie Weitkamp, with a Lifetime Achievement Award recognizing her pioneering research to understand salmon survival and recovery in the Northwest and beyond. Please join me in congratulating Laurie on this honor.

If it provides any inspiration to my colleagues in Fisheries, I want to share the mantra I have been repeating/singing to myself every single day. To quote Dory, one of the most famous fish in the history of the world, "Just Keep Swimming."

As always, thank you for your steady commitment to our mission.

Emily